

SESSION FIVE: DEAD LETTERS

The Qilvayas Symphony

An adventure for 4–6 characters of 5th level — the company's first contract, the document underworld, and the spymaster at the end of the thread

OVERVIEW

The party are graduates now: chartered, marked in sealed records as Proven, and open for business. Session Five is their first real contract — a deniable commission from the Lord Chamberlain's office to trace who has been buying the seals of dead imperial institutions — and it walks them through Rivergate's document underworld, into a chess match with the Office of Omens, through a dockside misunderstanding with professional consequences, and finally to a back office where the thread they have been pulling turns out to end in the hand of Mistress Averil Shen, the throne's own spymaster — who has been walking the same trail from the other end, because the trail was first walked by Empress Nyreeza.

Designed for a five-hour core. Pacing budget: the shingle and the clerk (45 minutes); Rivergate and the seal-dealer (75 minutes); the Office's attention (60 minutes); the Inkhands complication (45 minutes); the Shen reveal (60 minutes); closing choices (15 minutes). Optional content adds up to two further hours — see Optional Content. This is deliberately a light-combat session: one avoidable brawl and one avoidable ambush. The city is the dungeon; the corridors are made of people.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Three years ago, Empress Nyreeza needed to research the empire's oldest records without leaving a trail through official requisitions. Her method was elegant: she quietly purchased the seals of abolished imperial offices — dead institutions whose stamps still open archive doors, because no clerk in the empire is paid enough to question a seal that looks right — and used forged dead authority to work off the books. Mistress Averil Shen, reconstructing the Empress's last year step by step, discovered the method and has spent months buying up the same categories of dead seals: partly to retrace Nyreeza's access, partly to take the tool off the market before anyone else notices it exists.

Lord Chamberlain Kessin noticed anyway — not the why, only the pattern: someone with money and discipline is quietly cornering the market in defunct authority over Founder's Wall district records. Kessin suspects his rival Shen but cannot investigate her openly without tipping his hand, so he does what chamberlains do: he hires deniable outsiders. The party's commission is real, the pay is real, and the entire job is one court officer aiming a newly chartered mercenary company at another court officer without telling either of them. Meanwhile, the Office of Omens has the party under active surveillance — the copyist on Vaelindra's ground floor reports to the Office, and has for years (Vaelindra knows, and feeds the arrangement carefully curated chaff) — and Prelate Odell is building a jurisdictional case that the party's vision was Vaelindra's suggestion, which

would make her legally examinable. Every faction in this session is honest by its own lights. That is what makes it dangerous.

SCENE 1: THE SHINGLE AND THE CLERK

The company office is one flight above Master Verro's map shop on Coppergate's Fourth Lane: two rooms, one window that opens and one that lies about it, a strategic view of a laundry line, and — as of this morning — a sign. The sign took four days and two arguments. It hangs slightly crooked, which the landlady, the Widow Brakka, has already pointed out twice, along with the rent date, the house rules concerning "sorcery, livestock, and musicians," and the fact that she has taken the liberty of feeding you, because you are all far too thin to overthrow anything.

Open with texture and let the table enjoy it: the office, the sign (revisit the company name and charter from Session Zero — hang the charter on the wall, and beside it the Concord's register receipt, which is the half that actually matters and which the party queued for in Session Four), Brakka's tyrannical generosity, the first trickle of walk-in work offers (a lost cat with a suspiciously large reward; a merchant who wants his rival "lightly investigated"; decline or note for later). Fifteen to twenty minutes of the party simply being what they planned to become — the campaign owes them this beat before it complicates their lives again.

Then the clerk. Ossian Pell of the Chamberlain's office is young, gray-clothed, gray-mannered, and precisely as forgettable as his office trains its people to be. His offer, delivered from memory with the door closed: a commission, 150 gp on completion, strictly unattributed. Someone has been purchasing the seals and stamps of abolished imperial offices — specifically, in recent months, three offices whose defunct authority touches the census and property rolls of the Founder's Wall district, the oldest records in Aenodira. The chamberlery wishes to know who is buying, and why, and wishes to have never asked. A DC 14 Wisdom (Insight) check reads Pell as more nervous than the errand explains — he is; he knows who his master suspects, and saying it aloud in front of mercenaries is above his pay. He will confirm only: "Begin in Rivergate. There is a dealer. There is always a dealer."

SCENE 2: RIVERGATE — DEFUNCT & ANTIQUARIAN

Rivergate smells of tar, fish, ink, and negotiable virtue. Between a rope-walk and a chandlery stands a narrow shop whose signboard reads, in flaking gilt:

DEFUNCT & ANTIQUARIAN INSTRUMENTS OF OFFICE — T. MOSSE, PROP. — AUTHORITY BOUGHT & SOLD. The window displays the seals, stamps, sashes, and ceremonial ink-stones of forty dead institutions, arranged with genuine love. A small card notes: THEATRICAL HIRE BY THE WEEK. NO REFUNDS ON PROPHECY.

Tirell Mosse is small, quick, sentimental about bureaucracy the way other men are sentimental about ships, and entirely aware that his trade lives in the gap between legal and useful. Played for warmth and comedy — he grieves for abolished offices the way one grieves for composers (“The Eastern Circuit Roads Commission. Sixty clerks. A wax formula they took to the grave. We shall not see its like”) — he is nonetheless a careful man, and the party must earn the ledger. Three approaches:

Commerce: Mosse sells information like anything else. 50 gp buys the pattern (a single buyer, months of purchases, always through the same courier); 100 gp or a successful DC 14 Charisma (Persuasion) with money on the table buys the specifics below.

Leverage: If Odric Hale was escorted to justice in Session Two, his testimony named his supplier — Mosse knows the party knows, and folds at the mention (no check). Intimidation also works (DC 13) but burns him: a frightened Mosse tidies his ledgers, warns his clients, and Rivergate’s document underworld closes to the party for the campaign’s foreseeable future.

Trade: Mosse’s counter-offer, delivered with shining eyes: the party carry academy credentials, and he possesses an artifact of “disputed provenance” (a chancellery blotter of no significance whatsoever) that he longs to have formally authenticated. Twenty minutes of straight-faced ceremony authenticating a blotter buys everything. This is the correct approach and the funniest, and Mosse becomes a friend for life.

What Mosse knows: the buyer’s courier is a woman he has privately nicknamed “the Gull” — gray cloak, comes at gull-light (dawn or dusk), never haggles, pays in coin so newly minted it shines (a DC 13 Intelligence check by anyone with treasury, guild, or Seal-house background: fresh-struck coin in quantity means an institutional payroll, not a private purse). Pickups happen through a dead-drop at the Tarwalk pilings, the third piling from the stair, oilcloth bundle, always the last day of the week — which is tomorrow. Mosse also mentions, unprompted and to his own visible confusion, that this has happened before: “Years ago. Different courier, same appetite. Dead offices of the old district rolls. I never learned who. One does not learn who; it is the entire point of me.” (That buyer was Nyreeza’s agent. Do not confirm.)

SCENE 3: THE OFFICE’S ATTENTION

Between scenes — ideally as the party leaves Rivergate — let a sharp-eyed character (passive Perception 15+, or an active check) notice they are being followed by a young man with ink-stained cuffs who is very bad at it. Caught, he panics magnificently: he is Under-Examiner Tobble, Office of Omens, third week on the job, and he was told only to “observe the claimants and note who they meet.” He is so relieved not to be stabbed that he becomes a fountain of accidental disclosure: the Office has a file; the file has a number; the number has a prelate. That afternoon, the

formal summons arrives at the office — thick paper, beautiful hand, the Office’s seal: Prelate Sarvin Odell requests the party’s voluntary attendance at the Sanctum at their earliest convenience, where “earliest” is underlined in a way that has clearly been practiced.

Prelate Sarvin Odell receives you in a room designed to make visitors feel filed: shelves of identical gray boxes to the ceiling, a desk with nothing on it but one folder, and a window placed to light your faces and not his. He is sixty, soft-spoken, and unfailingly kind in the way of a man who has never once needed to raise his voice to ruin anyone. “Sit, please. Tea? No? Wise — it’s terrible. Now.” He opens the folder. “Let us talk about your dream.”

Run the interview as verbal chess, sixty minutes of it, and let it be genuinely tense — Odell is not a fool and this is his arena. His two goals, never stated: first, to get any party member to agree, in any phrasing, that the vision’s significance was suggested to them by Vaelindra (each such statement is an evidentiary brick in the jurisdictional wall he is building around her — a claimant influenced by an unsanctioned interpreter is Church business); second, failing that, to have the party voluntarily register as claimants of divine contact, which places them — and everyone who counsels them — under the Office’s examination authority. He probes with soft, precise questions: When did you first believe the dream mattered? Who told you it was shared? Who benefits from your belief? A Seal-house character recognizes the trap structure outright (no check); others may make DC 15 Wisdom (Insight) to feel the questions herding them. Safe answers exist — the vision was self-evidently shared before any consultation; no interpretation was sought, only historical context; the party claims nothing and therefore registers nothing — and Odell receives good answers with unfeigned professional pleasure, like a fencer saluting. Divergence outcomes at the end of this document. However it ends, his last line is the same:

“Thank you. You have been more helpful than you know — they always are, but you especially.” He closes the folder. “One kindness, freely given, because you are young and the woman is clever: whatever she is to you — historian, grandmother, oracle — the Matron’s law does not recognize the category. Categories are my work. I am very good at my work.”

SCENE 4: THE INKHANDS

The Tarwalk dead-drop must be watched to catch the Gull — which means a night among the pilings, and the pilings have owners. The Inkhands run protection on Rivergate’s document trade (their name is their contract: cross them and they blot you from the ledgers), and a crew of strangers lurking near Mosse’s dead-drop reads to them as exactly one thing: rival operators moving on their territory. Brune Halloc — broad, amiable, and carrying a boat-hook like punctuation — arrives with four Inkhand Enforcers (five for a party of five, six for six) to explain the misunderstanding the party is about to have.

This is a negotiation wearing a brawl’s clothes. Halloc genuinely prefers not to fight people with visible sword-calluses and academy posture; a DC 13 Charisma (Persuasion or Intimidation) — with advantage if the party invokes Mosse as a reference or offers the Inkhands’ standard “visitor’s consideration” (10 gp) — converts the confrontation into an arrangement, and Halloc’s crew will even keep casual watch

over the stakeout for professional courtesy. Scaling, if it comes to blows: baseline (4 characters) is Halloc plus 3 Inkhand Enforcers. For 5 characters, add 1 enforcer. For 6, add 2, and Halloc holds the gangplank so the party must come to him one or two at a time — which is how a dock boss who does not want a killing keeps it from becoming one. The Inkhands fight nonlethally with fists, hooks, and saps, quit at half strength, and hold no grudge afterward that a round of drinks cannot settle — but a party that draws steel and kills on the docks discovers that Rivergate remembers, the Garrison asks questions, and every ledger in the district develops sudden illiteracy regarding their inquiries.

SCENE 5: THE GULL, AND THE HAND AT THE END OF THE THREAD

At gull-light, she comes — gray cloak, unhurried, professionally forgettable. The party can shadow her (opposed Stealth; she is good, DC 16, and the route is designed to shed followers through a fish market and a temple crowd), intercept her (she does not resist, does not speak, and produces a writ of — of all things — the Bureau of Correspondence), or mark her and trace the route later. All roads lead to the same unmarked door behind the Bureau's public post-office frontage in the Exchange district, and through it — by invitation, because the moment the party commits to the door, it opens from within — to a small warm room with excellent tea and Mistress Averil Shen pouring it.

"Sit. The tea is good — unlike the Prelate's, which I'm told you had the sense to refuse." She is fifty, small, and stillness-made-flesh; the Gull stands at her shoulder like a folded letter. "You stalk like scholars, which is to say: loudly, but with excellent notes. So. The Chamberlain has hired children to find out what I am buying, and the children have actually found me, which is more than his last three attempts managed. Before we discuss what you will tell him — and we will — I am going to show you why the question matters, because someone in this city ought to know besides me." She sets a single sheet on the table. "I have spent two years buying dead seals to learn how a living Empress vanished. She bought them first. She was cleverer than all of us. And on the last day anyone saw her, she filed one final document under a dead office's authority — and I cannot read it." The sheet is covered in a careful, hurried cipher. Whoever carries the Cold Door rubbing feels their pulse jump: it is the same hand.

Shen's proposition: pool what they hold — her requisition trail and the ciphered document against the party's rubbing and their academy access to Vell — and pursue the Empress's trail together, quietly, off every book in the empire. Her terms are blunt: Kessin gets a cover story (she will even draft it — "the buyer was a Velmarene collector; the trail is cold"), Odell gets nothing, and the throne gets nothing until there is something worth a throne's attention, because — and here she is honest in a way that costs her — "the Empress hid this from her own son. I have wondered for three years whether she was protecting the investigation from the court, or protecting him from the answer. Until I know which, neither will I." What the party does with all of this — the alliance, the cover story, the truth owed or not owed to Pell and Kessin —

is the session's closing choice, and every option forks (see Diverging Paths). Pay them their 150 gp regardless: whatever they report, the commission was technically completed. Session ends on the walk home from the Bureau, the city lamplit, one of them carrying two documents in the same dead woman's hand.

OPTIONAL CONTENT (BEYOND THE FIVE-HOUR CORE)

The Bartleby Provision (~45 minutes): A formal letter from Professor Dail: with the Undervault's eastern wing under masonry, its resident "custodial asset" requires temporary care, and the party are the only living graduates it likes. Bartleby is delivered to the company office in a crate labeled ABSOLUTELY FURNITURE. What follows is a landlady crisis (Brakka's house rules did not anticipate this and she negotiates with the mimic directly, and wins), a client meeting conducted while a cabinet breathes in the corner, and — the buried payload — a moment late at night where Bartleby, who has lived above the Undercourt for four centuries, refuses to imitate anything and simply watches the floor, and the medallion in the desk drawer goes cold. Comedy that ends on a single quiet chill: even the joke NPC knows something is down there.

A Night at the Patched Standard (~30 minutes): The company's local: a scholars' and soldiers' tavern off Scholar's Row whose sign is a legion banner darned so many times that regulars claim it is now entirely made of repairs, "like the empire." Use it to celebrate the charter: Fenn appears and holds court on the party's Proving performance; Professor Vorn (if met in Session Two) is mid-lecture at the corner table, to pigeons of the human variety; a toast to absent friends lands on Dren's medallion and goes quiet in the good way. Pure texture and bond-maintenance — the scenes players remember when the campaign later gets dark.

The Farrowgate Client (~45 minutes): A knock after hours: a Farrowgate mother — one of Semya's people if they were not resettled, a stranger if they were — whose daughter took good wages at a castle in the Suthmark hills and stopped writing four months ago. She coughs twice while she talks — into her sleeve, with the practiced economy of someone who has been doing it for years — and apologizes for it, which is somehow worse. It is the Damp, Farrowgate's own complaint, bred by the district's crowding and its standing water; it is mundane, it has nothing to do with anything under the city, and the DM should resist every instinct to make it mean more than it does. A cleric in the party can end the active case in six seconds and will not have touched the cause. She cannot pay. She has brought, because it is everything she has, a jar of preserved plums and the daughter's letters — the last of which mentions "the Countess's kindness" and the odd rule that the maids must never draw well-water after dark. Taking the case (there is no fee; there is only whether they are the kind of company that takes it) formally opens the Greywell arc for a future module and marks the party, in the campaign's quiet ledger, as the people who came for the girls' sake. Declining is also a choice, and the jar of plums stays on the shelf either way, where everyone can see it.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

Record outcomes in the Branch Ledger.

The report to Kessin: Truth (naming Shen) makes the party Kessin's proven instrument — better Highcourt access, future commissions, and Shen's cold, patient enmity: the alliance dies unborn and the Nyreeza trail must be walked without the spymaster's half of the evidence. Shen's cover story keeps the alliance and plants a lie in the Chamberlain's ledger that he may one day trace — if he does, the party's Highcourt credit burns at the worst possible moment. Refusing to report at all returns the fee and marks them, in Kessin's book, as honest and useless — the safest and least rewarded branch.

The Odell interview: Clean answers (no attribution to Vaelindra, no registration) deny the Office its bricks: the Session Six writ proceeds on weaker grounds and the legal counter-play there gains advantage. Any attribution statement strengthens the writ. Voluntary registration as claimants gives the Office lawful examination authority over the party themselves — a leash that will be pulled. Open defiance or insult accelerates everything and adds the party to the writ by name.

Mosse — cultivated vs. burned: Cultivated (commerce or the blotter ceremony), he becomes the campaign's standing window into the document underworld and a source of future leads. Burned (intimidation, exposure), Rivergate's paper trade closes to the party, and a future session's forged-document need becomes materially harder.

The Inkhands: An arrangement makes the docks friendly: eyes, small favors, and a warning the night something worse comes upriver. Blood makes the docks a place the party gets watched from doorways, forever.

The Farrowgate client (optional): Taken, the Greywell arc opens with the party as protagonists of conscience. Declined, the arc still exists — but it will eventually arrive as news of what happened while nobody came, which is a different kind of scene.

STAT BLOCKS

Inkhand Enforcer

Medium humanoid (any race), neutral

Armor Class: 11 (leather armor)

Hit Points: 32 (5d8 + 10)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

Skills: Athletics +4, Intimidation +2

Senses: passive Perception 10

Languages: Common, dockside cant

Challenge: 1 (200 XP)

Pack Tactics. The enforcer has advantage on attack rolls against a creature if at least one ally is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally isn't incapacitated.

Professional Standards. The enforcer fights nonlethally by default (saps, fists, boat-hooks reversed) and quits at half hit points or when Halloc calls it. Killing is bad for the ledgers.

ACTIONS

Multiaction. The enforcer makes two sap attacks.

Sap. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) bludgeoning damage (nonlethal by default).

Brune Halloc

Medium humanoid (human), neutral

Armor Class: 13 (thick coat, quick head)

Hit Points: 45 (7d8 + 14)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
17 (+3)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)

Skills: Athletics +5, Insight +3, Intimidation +4, Persuasion +4

Senses: passive Perception 11

Languages: Common, dockside cant, river-sign

Challenge: 2 (450 XP)

The Reasonable Option. Halloc offers terms before, during, and after violence. Any turn in which a hostile creature speaks to him instead of attacking, he will pause his crew to hear it out.

ACTIONS

Multiaction. Halloc makes two boat-hook attacks.

Boat-Hook. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (1d8 + 3) bludgeoning damage, and Halloc can pull a Medium or smaller target 5 feet toward him (his negotiating distance).

REACTIONS

Hold Fast. When an ally within 10 feet is reduced to half its hit points, Halloc calls the fight: his crew disengages and negotiations reopen at once.

Office Examiner

Medium humanoid (any race), lawful neutral

Armor Class: 14 (breastplate under gray robes)

Hit Points: 22 (4d8 + 4)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
12 (+1)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)

Skills: Insight +4, Investigation +3, Religion +3

Senses: passive Perception 12

Languages: Common, Old Imperial

Challenge: 1/2 (100 XP)

Instruments of Examination. The examiner carries a mancatcher, weighted cords, and sealed scrolls of restraint. Its purpose is custody, never death; it always attacks nonlethally and always announces its writ first.

ACTIONS

Mancatcher. Melee Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, reach 10 ft., one Medium or Small creature. Hit: 4 (1d6 + 1) bludgeoning damage, and the target is grappled (escape DC 12). The examiner can't use the mancatcher on another target while it grapples.

Scroll of Binding (1/day). The examiner reads a sealed scroll: one creature it can see within 30 feet must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw or be restrained by cords of gray light for 1 minute (save at end of each turn). The scroll is consumed.

NPC PROFILES

CLERK OSSIAN PELL

Human, mid-20s, the Chamberlain's office in miniature: gray, precise, forgettable by training. Speech: memorized phrasing, visible relief when questions stay inside the phrasing. Thread: Pell is the party's barometer for Kessin's regard — as their Highcourt standing rises or falls, Pell's manner (and the quality of the commissions he carries) shifts first.

TIRELL MOSSE

Human, 50s, dealer in defunct authorities and mourner of dead institutions. Speech: elegies for abolished offices; italicized discretion ("One does not learn who; it is the entire point of me"). Thread: cultivated, he is the document underworld's friendliest door and will someday sell the party something that matters enormously; burned, that door — and everything behind it — closes.

PRELATE SARVIN ODELL

Human, 60s, head of the Office of Omens; the antagonist of this arc and never once rude about it. Speech: soft, exact, kind in the way of surgeons; asks questions he has already answered in the file. He believes, sincerely, that unlicensed prophecy kills people — he has case files where it did — and that Vaelindra is a fifty-year failure of Church discipline he intends to correct before he retires. Thread: Odell is beatable by law, by politics, or by making his case collapse — but never by argument, and making it personal makes it worse. His file on the party survives every branch.

BRUNE HALLOC

Human, 40s, Inkhand crew boss; violence as a customer-service failure. Speech: dockside proverbs, terms offered mid-swing. Thread: an arrangement with Halloc quietly makes the party "known on the docks," which in Rivergate is a currency.

MISTRESS AVERIL SHEN

Human, 50, Keeper of the Bureau of Correspondence; the stillest person in any room. Speech: economical, dry, honest exactly when honesty is the sharper instrument. Her loyalty question is the campaign's live wire: she was Nyreeza's creature, serves Qilvayas faithfully, and is withholding from him the one investigation he would most want — because his mother did. Thread: the alliance, if formed, gives the party the empire's best intelligence and its most dangerous friend; every secret they share with Shen is also a secret Shen has.

THE WIDOW BRAKKA

Landlady, nationality unestablished and fiercely maintained as such, feeds everyone, fears nothing, negotiated with a mimic and won. Speech: rent dates and endearments in the same sentence. Thread: none. She is texture, and she is load-bearing texture; protect her at all costs.

LOOT AND FOUND

REWARDS — SESSION FIVE — DEAD LETTERS

Find	Value / Effect
Commission & incidentals	Canon (150 gp; up to 100 gp Rivergate earnings)
Mosse's goodwill (if cultivated)	A standing 10% at Defunct & Antiquarian, and first refusal on 'items of academic interest' — a loot table that walks in the door every few sessions
Inkhand arrangement	Dock intelligence; one free 'misplaced cargo' favor

REWARDS AND ADVANCEMENT

Coin: 150 gp commission (paid on any report), up to 100 gp in incidental Rivergate earnings, and Brakka's cooking. Relationships are the true treasure: Mosse, Halloc, Pell, and above all the Shen alliance — or its absence — define the campaign's intelligence landscape from here forward. Items: Shen's ciphered document (Nyreeza's final filing — unreadable until combined with the rubbing and Vell, Session Six), and optionally a jar of preserved plums with a weight out of all proportion to its size. XP for tables using it: roughly 900–1,300 depending on route (full value for every avoided fight). Milestone: the party remains 5th level; 6th comes at the Second Seal.

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